

RULER AND MILITARY LEADER Born 356 BCE Died 323 BCE

Alexander the Great

“There is **nothing impossible** to him
who will try”

ATTRIBUTED TO ALEXANDER THE GREAT

In less than a decade of warfare, Alexander of Macedon, known as “the Great,” created one of the largest land empires the world has ever seen, stretching from Greece to northern India. His career of conquest was built upon that of his father, Philip II, king of Macedon in Greece. It was Philip who turned the kingdom of Macedon into a regional power in the Greek world. He created the army of heavy cavalry and pike-wielding infantry that became the instrument for Alexander’s empire building.

From an early age Alexander was marked out among Philip’s children as his most likely successor—he acted as regent of Macedon and keeper of the royal seal while Philip was making an expedition against Byzantium in 340 BCE. At the age of 18 he proved his courage and skill in war, leading a cavalry charge at the battle of Chaeronea in 338 BCE that crushed the Sacred Band—the famed elite Greek infantry from Thebes. Yet his right to the succession was by no means assured, for the throne did not necessarily pass to



Alexander in action

This Roman mosaic shows Alexander riding his horse Bucephalus into battle against the Persians at Issus in 333 BCE. Leading his army from the front, Alexander was never defeated in battle, despite fighting armies three times the size of his own.